IN TECH WE TRUST.

The god-like authority of technology in the modern age - and what it means to set a wiser course

Life Itself
Sensemaking Studio

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Introduction

This essay is part of a series examining features of a globalised society in crisis, and exploring how a shift in fundamental views and values - a new cultural paradigm - might support a wiser, regenerative future.

A foundational paper outlines the idea of a cultural paradigm shift or 'Second Renaissance.'[1] Forthcoming essays will build on this inquiry, exploring its implications for specific areas of society - such as climate, decision-making, education, and more.

We first address **technology** because it has become a special case: a force so powerful that it has shaped not only our material conditions, but also the deepest cultural foundations of our shared world; offering a lens through which many of our wider challenges can be understood. Since prehistory, humans have created, depended upon, and been shaped by technology - enabling our lives in countless ways. Yet this complex relationship has grown increasingly problematic. In recent decades, as climate breakdown escalates and AI accelerates, it has reached a crisis point.

Beneath the surface, many of today's global challenges can be traced to particular features of our shared worldview, anchored in the cultural paradigm of modernity. The structural and cultural features of our societies - including our relationship with technology - arise from foundational systems of beliefs: shared ways of seeing ourselves, each other, and the world. Elsewhere we've referred to these systems of views and values as 'cultural paradigms.'

The modern paradigm is unique, however, in that unprecedented technological advancement - and its profound effect on human power dynamics - has elevated technology to a primary metaphor within the cultural paradigm itself.[2] Accelerated by the industrial revolution and further still in the digital age, technology is not just a tool of modernity, but one of its chief organising logics: reciprocally shaping how we view

[1] Barbier et al. (2024)

[2] Machine metaphors for life appeared before the modern age (see e.g. Riskin (2013)) however their dominance was entrenched by the industrial revolution, proliferating with each new wave of empowering tech (e.g. mind as computer.) See e.g. Mumford (1967).

reality and imagine the human good. In what follows, we explore key features of late modernity's increasingly dysfunctional relationship with technology, and consider the shifts in worldview and inner capacity that may be necessary to support wiser choice-making for the future.

Key features of the modern cultural paradigm relating to technology

Throughout the essay we'll discuss particular views and assumptions, core to the modern worldview, that shape or are shaped by our relationship with technology.[3] These include:

Material reality as paramount

Since the scientific revolution, modern society has limited 'reality' to that which can be seen and measured - grounding truth in the material and dismissing the subjective and spiritual as secondary or unreal.

The myth of progress

Enlightenment philosophers proposed that human history follows an inevitable trajectory towards *improvement* in both cultural and material dimensions.[4] Influenced also by the Industrial Revolution, modern culture has particularly associated what's better for humanity with increased comfort arising from economic growth and technological development - an ongoing teleology of improvement wherein more new technology is always better.

Technology as a primary cosmological metaphor

As increasingly powerful mechanisms have empowered humanity in countless ways, modern culture has come to view life and the cosmos as a complex machine; no more than the sum of separate material parts, and the smallest parts most fundamental. This

[3] Barbier et al. (2024) offers a more general summary of views and values core to the modern cultural paradigm. See also Walker (2021).

[4] See e.g. Kleingeld (1999) on Kant

mechanistic view has gradually supplanted older, relational and sacred views of life and reality, helping to cement reductive materialism as the dominant view.[5]

Individualism

A related, similarly reductive model characterises modernity's dominant view of humanity: a collection of separate individuals, in competition for resources and dominance. Within secular modernity the individual is the locus of all meaning - with autonomy, self-interest, and personal success among our guiding values.

Rationalism and freedom

Modernity elevates reason and logic as the ultimate source of knowledge - and the defining quality of human nature. Governed by rationality (in contrast to e.g. emotion or faith), human beings are seen as free to choose what is best. Furthermore, since the advent of computer technology, the metaphor of life-as-machine has taken on a new mantle: *mind-as-computer* - reinforcing rationalism as the obvious model of human nature.

Homo economicus

Modern economics - particularly in the form of neoliberal or market fundamentalism - rests on a view of human beings as rational, self-interested individuals who make decisions based on stable preferences and free choice in competitive markets.[6]

Shifting our relationship with technology for a wiser future

With these cultural views and values in mind, we'll examine dysfunctional features of the late (post) modern relationship with technology and propose two deep shifts in this relationship that could be foundational to a healthy future society:

***From**: out-of-control tech, arising from collective action problems (rooted in modern individualism and reductivism)*

[5] For expansion see Merchant (1980)

[6] Kahneman (1979) is one early work that undermines the idea of Homo Economicus, the rational, self-interested decision-maker.

To*: collective restraint, supported by a worldview of interbeing.*

From*: a tyranny of technology, arising from a rationalist illusion of human agency and freedom*
To*: wiser choice founded on holistic understanding of human nature and attunement to an inner compass.*

1. Co-evolving with our tools

Humans have co-evolved with technologies, which shape our bodies, behaviours, and societies. What feels different now is the speed, scale, and irreversibility of tech's influence.

We commonly hear the complaint that "technology has taken over our lives". However, humans have been creating technology for millennia. More than just creating - for almost as long, we have co-evolved with and depended upon the artefacts and processes that we have developed. Genetics, culture and technology interact to constitute humanity. Hundreds of thousands of years ago for example, our use of fire altered our digestion and social habits; our clothing altered group psychology and even our bodies; tools altered our capacity for creation and adaptation to new niches.[7] Early communication technologies became fundamental to group dynamics, social stability and thus survival.[8]

In short, for as long as humans have used technology to enable our lives, we have to some extent been 'cyborgs' - technology necessarily alters our behaviours and psychology - even our bodies - becoming part of who and what we are.[9]

Likewise, significant leaps in technology have often been greeted with suspicion and ridicule, at least by some - consider attitudes to the first automated vehicles. Throughout the history of technology, radical innovations have felt improbable and dangerous, generating resistance that appears futile with the benefit of hindsight. Yet intuitively it still feels as if something is different about the current age and its

[7] See e.g. Wrangham (2009), Gilligan (2010)
[8] See e.g. Lent (2017)
[9] See e.g. Haraway (1991)

relationship with tech. The scale at which technology now shapes our being, the pace at which it changes, the readiness with which such change is adopted and perhaps most importantly, the *irreversibility* of certain changes are an increasing source of concern. As we'll discuss, tech and technological priorities have come to drive our society to an unprecedented degree - perhaps even transforming from a tool that we create to a force that creates *us*.

2. Aspects of the late-modern relationship with technology

2.1 Technology as God

Modern society increasingly relates to technology as a surrogate god. We trust, revere, and submit to tech - while elevating technologists as cultural high priests shaping the fate of our world.

From Galileo to Newton, the foundational thinkers of modern science did not set out to seed a secular worldview - seeking more to understand a divine cosmos than to erase it.[10] Nonetheless the march of rationalism, empirical science and industrialisation since the 17th century fundamentally redirected western epistemology: from religion as the sole origin of truth and authority, to the material world and human reason as primary loci of admissible facts and knowledge. Religion was not extinguished, but gradually lost its central status as a source of sense-making for all society.

[10] Noble (1997) argues that religion and technology were never separate - technology in the secular age bearing imprints of a time when science and technology were seen as vessels of and routes to divine knowledge.

Nonetheless, the need for something-like-religion as a organising principle and locus of devotion never went away. As a source of power, transformation and significant awe and mystery, science and technology became natural successors. In our secular, late modern age, with the rise of advanced digital tech, humanity relates to technology ever more as to a god.

If the suggestion that we have come to worship technology seems a little sensational, it's worth considering the surprising number of divine functions that have found a material surrogate in late modernity. We both revere and defer to the forces unleashed by technology and capitalism; allowing them to run our world, and to shape our being.

Tech as divine mystery

Since the 19th century, the rise of evolutionary theory has largely supplanted creationism as a dominant narrative in secular societies. Nonetheless, even while dismissing the supernatural, modern humanity is devoted to tech as to a divine force. And tech more than lives up to the hype. After all, we fly in aeroplanes. We access a world of knowledge from the smartphones in our pockets. We navigate by satellite and look at scans of the inside of our bodies, to perform lifesaving operations using robot arms. Our computers can listen to our conversations and write us a speech. And most of us certainly can't comprehend *how*. It's all so mysterious, it might as well be magic.[11] Understandably, we are awe-struck, in ways that resemble our former relationship with the church and the power of prayer. From where I'm standing, there's no discernible difference between the internet and an omniscient being - except that the former answers questions with a higher degree of reliability. I don't ask how it works. I just switch it on and trust.[12]

[11] As Clarke's third law has it, "Any sufficiently advanced technology is indistinguishable from magic." See also Davis (1998)

[12] Harari, (2016) suggests that humanism is being replaced by 'dataism' - a new religion that treats life as information processing and algorithms as objects of faith.

In tech we trust

We allow technology God-like permission to shape our lives, psychologically and physically, often without question. Consider computerised capitalism, managing global markets - and our meek submission to digital market forces. We have normalised addiction to our smartphones; and 'consume' our world through social media, trusting the precious resource of our attention to aggressive, algorithmic data-driven advertising.[13]

Trust in technology extends beyond quotidian choicemaking - even shaping our collective response to existential threat. For example, at the highest levels of climate policy and planning, leading emissions scenarios increasingly rely on assumptions of future technological breakthroughs - especially in carbon removal - to meet global targets; amounting to blind faith in technology in a crisis of apocalyptic dimensions.[14]

Salvation in tech

The transcendental hopes that once energised mass worship - including the possibility of eternal life - have also acquired a new, technological basis in late modernity. Companies have begun offering cryopreservation at death, in expectation that when the tech matures, their clients' consciousness can be electronically revived. Transhumanists consider this imagined silicon future an upgrade: go-faster life, requiring less energy. A super-human technology that replaces human being in hosting human consciousness.[15] Ideas that were once science fiction are drawing closer to reality: the idea of cryopreservation has evolved "from crackpot to merely eccentric."[16]

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[13] See e.g. Howard (2021)

[14] See e.g. Dyke et. al (2021)

[15] Well before AI or cryonics became an imminent prospect, Noble (1997) drew links between a tech obsessed society and a religious transcendence of mortal life. Zak Stein (2024) discusses the alarming implications of transhumanism.

[16] Howard (2024)

The divine right of technologists

Nothing demonstrates the priorities of a society like the profile of the people they deify - and look to for answers. For the current society, the big men of tech often fulfil this role. From Steve Jobs to Elon Musk, the most famous people in the world are tech founders and, alive or dead, their opinion is thought relevant in every matter. Prestige, respect and intellectual prowess are attached to tech like no other sector. It's perhaps no coincidence that (High Priest) Elon Musk leans strongly towards libertarianism, disliking the suggestion of any limits being applied to power, and using that power to transform politics towards reduced state intervention.[17]

2.2 From Servant to Master

Traditionally a powerful servant, improving comfort, health, and connection, technology has today grown into a dominant ideology - often eclipsing human values and becoming more master than servant.

"There is a Zen story about a person sitting on a horse, galloping very quickly. At a crossroads, a friend of his shouts, "Where are you going?" The man says, "I don't know, ask the horse!"
This is our situation. The horse is technology. It carries us and we cannot control it. So we have to begin with intention, asking ourselves, what do we want?

- Zen Master Thich Nhat Hanh[18]

The simple fact that physicists split the atom without any hesitations the very moment they knew how to do it, although they realized full well the enormous destructive potentialities of their

[17] This essay was drafted several months before the second Trump Administration appointed Musk to lead 'DOGE' (Department of Government Efficiency), handing the technologist unfettered access to agency computer systems and significant control over federal government spending.
[18] Thich nhat Hanh (2013)

operation, demonstrates that the scientist qua scientist does not even care about the survival of the human race on earth or, for that matter, about the survival of the planet itself.

- Hannah Arendt (1993)

Technology is a tremendous servant. Many of us benefit from it in myriad ways: we heat and cool our homes, have enough food and medicine, use transport, communicate at a distance, and enjoy extraordinary entertainment. As such, in the modern west, we generally expect more technology to improve our lives - a stance reflected in the choices we make at a societal level. When leaders, politicians and managers promote 'innovation', the term often functions as shorthand for technological tools and fixes; effectively sidelining other the human good in a great deal of civic decision-making. Innovation agendas centre around problems amenable to technological intervention - leaving far less room for inquiries into how we might innovate in ways that deepen qualities such as kindness or empathy.

Conversely, *restriction* of technology is often frowned upon in policy and in discourse. To question technological progress is still an attitude considered, if not taboo, then at least rather naïve - and futile.[19] 'Capital T' Technology has become a whole dominant ideology, often without the human dimensions essential to any desirable political programme[20] - increasingly crossing the line from servant to master.

The flaws in this attitude are writ large in current planetary crises. Technological capitalism is pushing ecological systems towards collapse, virtually unchecked. The solutions deemed acceptable within high-level climate policymaking (such as at COP) anticipate more technology that can reverse the harm that existing technology creates.[21] From climate to AI, nuclear proliferation and more, even as the disastrous consequences

[19] See e.g. Zuboff (2019).
[20] As Hannah Arendt (1993) observed, modern politics increasingly treats factual–scientific truth as authoritative while displacing the value-laden realm of human judgement, with profound consequences for political responsibility and freedom.
[21] See e.g. Dyke et. al (2021).

become clearly visible, we still allow technology and technologists above all others to make our decisions.

Utility and the rational fallacy

We tell ourselves that technology arises to meet human needs, and rarely pause before rolling it out. Entrenched faith in rationalism - a profoundly limited view of human nature - maintains an illusion of choice; enabling the tools we build to distort our agency and externalise harm unchecked. Reason is not sovereign in the way the modern market story requires it to be - and the accumulated harm of this fallacy is laid bare by the tech-fuelled destruction of the living world.

While the path to innovation is often shaped by power dynamics, financial agendas, curiosity and even accident, it's commonly legitimised by a narrative of utility: first a need (or desire) arises, then innovation emerges to meet it.[22] Perhaps this seductively straightforward framing discourages deeper questioning - leading us to assume that if something can be created, it should be, without pausing to ask whether its integration into our lives truly serves our best interests. Human history offers few notable cases of wholesale restriction of specific technologies: typically, once a machine proves effective, it is adopted and widely implemented - often without comprehensive debate about long-term consequences.[23] Throughout modernity this approach has delivered extraordinary leaps in material comfort for many - at a scale that can at first make critique seem churlish.

[22] Edgerton (2006) critiques the myth of utility.

[23] Among notable historical exceptions, as fictionalised in Clavell's (1975) *Shogun*, the Tokugawa Shogunate implemented strict control over the production and ownership of weapons, including European muskets, following their first import and use in battle in the 1600s. While such policies were aimed principally at maintaining power, the wisdom of perceiving the potential of firearms to create instability is implicit. Today, some genetic technologies, like human cloning, are legally banned in many countries. AI and facial recognition are beginning to face ethical and regulatory pushback in certain regions.

This story of utility predates modern times, but has been entrenched by a core dogma of the dominant cultural paradigm: rationalism. Within modern market economics, the normative model of human nature is *homo economicus:* the individual, rational agent making decisions that serve their own best interests, based on observation and reason.[24] Capitalist faith in the market to deliver the human good rests on the sovereign rational consumer choosing what they want, and wanting what's best. The same assumptions apply to technology. Within this framework, those who fail to choose in their own best interests are seen as deficient: ill-informed, immature (like children) or unwell (like addicts).[25] The harm caused by the capitalist technological system is dismissed through the notion of 'externality': we *are* choosing what's good for us, and any resulting damage must be to something "external", outside ourselves or our sphere or concern – as if by accident.

In today's world, it takes a particular kind of blindness to cling to a simple legitimising narrative of utility and rational choice. The fiction of externality is laid bare by the climate crisis: there is no separate world into which to export the consequences of our individual choices - only a vast accumulation of collective harm that mocks the idea of the benevolent market. The psychology of addiction should have debunked 'homo economicus' long before 'normal' adults found themselves dependent upon their smartphones. Instead, we have normalised dopamine-fuelled systems in which attention is hijacked and sold for profit; fracturing our awareness, fragmenting communities, deepening political polarisation and corroding mental health. From behavioural economics to evolutionary psychology, evidence shows that human decision-making is emotional, heuristic, impulsive, and adaptive, as well as belief-, value-, and ultimately technology-driven before it is rational.

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[24] Daniel Kahneman famously dismantled the idea of Homo Economicus, the rational, self-interested decision-maker, in his work with Amos Tversky on prospect theory. Thaler & Sunstein (2008) recast the mythical sovereign consumer as "Econ".

[25] See e.g. Thaler & Sunstein (2008)

Case study: the Zen Master visits Google

In 2013, Zen Master Thich Nhat Hanh was invited to Google Headquarters, to guide discussions on good use of technology, supporting people to take good care of themselves and suffer less. He conversed with engineers about intention, innovation and insight, and naturally the conversation turned to the negative health impacts of addictive technology, particularly smartphone apps. He made a suggestion:

Contemplatives at plum village make use of a mindfulness bell; a sound every quarter hour to recall them to themselves and to awareness. Mobile phones can easily support this kind of feature: a regular bell to interrupt exactly the addictive pattern that makes them so harmful, and signal that it's time to take a breath and notice that you are alive.

But then, argued the engineer, *wouldn't we be imposing on people something they don't need?*

It's really not so simple, The Zen Master answered. *People's responses can come from real needs or false needs. Consider food: hunger can signal a real need to eat. But many people eat to escape their suffering. The same is true with technology. It can serve real needs, but often you're serving sensations to people to conceal their suffering – loneliness, anxiety and more. You have to help people distinguish, and take care of the real needs, like going home to themselves.* [26]

The engineer's objection demonstrates perfectly the naive faith in individual freedom of choice written throughout our modern relationship with tech. *We don't impose a wellbeing feature, we allow people to choose according to their needs.* The dominant ethic at play in this decision-making is free choice, with the same rational model implicit. However, as the Zen Master implies, choice is little good to us absent the skill or capacity to choose well. Some rules of our current society demonstrate that we *know* this. We don't allow ten year-olds to choose to drink alcohol; or people suffering from

[26] Thich Nhat Hanh (2014)

dementia to write a new will. But the story of *homo economicus* prevails despite the fact that for *all* of us, at any time in life, our ability to choose can be enhanced or occluded by internal and external factors. The prevalence of distraction, for example, the depletion of our willpower, or pollution of the information available to us - all effects of unregulated smartphone use - are all factors that corrode our choice-making capacity more generally.

The depth of our belief in our own rational capacity to choose well is among the factors underpinning technology's shift from servant to master. Believing ourselves fully agentic, and enhanced by technology, we blind ourselves to the potential for technology to distort our agency.

Tech as creator

As technologies evolve and embed themselves into daily life, they don't merely direct us - they shape us, rewiring our cognition, attention, and ways of being.

Consider consumer digital technology. In *The Shallows*, Nicholas Carr argues that thanks to our relationship with computers and the internet, particularly over the last 20 years, the average brain is being rewired for short attention span and superficial engagement, with profound consequences for memory, communication and human relationship - not to mention depth of understanding.[27] Our ability to *search* for the information we need in these contexts is growing, but our ability to *remember* is neglected and declining. The earliest millennials (including the authors) grew up in a world where finding out typically meant either asking someone who knew, or locating and reading a book, and remembering its content. The transformation of this process with the advent of the internet, and then more drastically the smartphone, carried wherever we go, has dramatically reshaped the average brain.

[27] Carr (2011)

We allow technology to shape our physical being too, for better *and* worse. We drive instead of walking; eat ultra-processed food produced by big agri-business; submit to digital dopamine hacking; craft our bodies to social-media-driven beauty standards. (At the same time giant technological leaps in agriculture, healthcare and more have radically improved physical quality of life for the average human, compared to previous ages.)

As noted above, human beings have always been shaped by the technologies we create - from cooking to literacy. Yet aspects of today's technological landscape are uniquely alarming. First, the **pace**: new mind- and body-altering technologies emerge rapidly, and are often adopted with little reflection. At both policy and personal levels, they are integrated into daily life far faster than our collective sensemaking can match. By the time society begins to understand and evaluate a technology, it may already be deeply entrenched in economic structures, habits, and dependencies that make change difficult. Second, the **complexity**: contemporary technologies are intricate, both in themselves and in how they interact with each other, with human psychology, and with the wider ecosphere. Finally, the **impact**: unlike previous innovations, many of these technologies reach directly into our minds and bodies in unprecedented ways - before we even begin to consider the destructive capacity of modern weaponry (including bioweaponry) or the irreversible toll of intensifying tech on the biosphere. All of the above expresses a growing **wisdom gap**: the impact and momentum of technology escalates at the same time as our capacity to choose well is increasingly compromised.[28]

[28] See e.g. Mulgan & Pollock (2020)

2.3 AI: the logical conclusion of modern attitudes to tech?

The rise of AI amplifies longstanding patterns of rapid, uncritical tech adoption - escalating power without precaution, and raising urgent questions society is not prepared to answer. With no true experts in the social impact of emerging technologies, we risk repeating past mistakes on a vastly more consequential scale.

Humanity is about to be handed almost unimaginable power, and it is deeply unclear whether our social, political, and technological systems possess the maturity to wield it.

- Dario Amodei[29]

The dawn of AI demonstrates the wisdom gap at warp speed, bringing the question of rapid tech adoption to the forefront of public discourse with an urgency unseen since the arrival of nuclear technology. As technological power accelerates, AI expands the horizon of the possible so dramatically that what we once called an 'advanced technological age' suddenly looks more like a technological adolescence - volatile, overpowered and not necessarily survivable.[30] Awareness is growing that exponential technologies, amplified by unfettered techno-capitalism, carry profound risks – a recognition sharpened by the accumulating social consequences of heedless smartphone adoption.

In late 2022, the release of ChatGPT propelled AI's possibilities and future trajectories into mainstream public debate, with anxiety growing around the potential threats that exponential AI could pose in the longer term.[31]

[29] AI researcher and Head of Anthropic

[30] Amodei (2026) develops Sagan's concept of tech adolescence

[31] A classic thought experiment from Bostrom (2014) resurfaced: the emergence of a superintelligent AI that destroys the world, having been instructed to optimise for making as many paperclips as possible out of available resources.

Aside from the sudden popularity of the 'paperclip maximiser' question and its variants, the public witnessed first-hand the disruption that rapid adoption of such powerful new tech can bring. For example, the sudden public availability of a machine that can plagiarise anything from a GCSE coursework essay to a Master's thesis in a few clicks left educators thoroughly destabilised in new, unregulated territory. The consequences of chatbot automation chatbots are still unfolding through creative industries. Meanwhile, present-day, direct environmental costs of AI such as water theft and intense energy consumption are often minimised.[32]

The possibility of Artificial General Intelligence (AGI) - a fully autonomous system with cognitive abilities comparable to a person - is still contested. But whatever its likelihood or timeline, the sheer scale of uncertainty of its potential consequences demands precautionary scrutiny. *In a world where we still struggle to reliably bring up our human children, to feed and cherish them properly, would we wish to bring into existence a superhuman child powerful enough to destroy all life, just because we could?* Arguably however, the most realistic threat of AI is not that it might truly become *conscious*, but that it could become supremely powerful *without* fully dimensional (embodied, emotional) consciousness - accelerating our current relationship with tech towards a logical conclusion where we lack the capacity to resist its authority.[33]

The actual likelihood of such an invention matters less than the fact that if it *was* invented, our deference to technology excludes the checks and balances, the precautionary sense-making, needed to resist it. So while it's tempting to leave mind-bending questions such as the ethics of artificial consciousness to 'the experts', this is precisely the problem: when it comes to exponential future technology and its consequences for society, there *are* no experts yet.

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[32] Cadwallr (2025), de Vries Gao (2026).

[33]Some innovators themselves warn of deeper concerns about loss of human oversight, systemic fragility, and the long-term alignment of increasingly autonomous AI with human values. E.g. Amodei (2026.

No experts in the effect of smartphone use on youth mental health were available to consult when we handed addictive technology to young people at the scale of whole populations. No experts in the effect of algorithm-driven disinformation were there, when we adopted unregulated social media as a new primary medium of the public sphere. The closest thing to experts that we have at such moments are the innovators heavily invested in creating and selling the technology itself. In the case of AI, many see and articulate the risks they are accelerating - but the competitive, geopolitical, and economic dynamics make non-participation feel unrealistic - even irresponsible. Historically, by the time experts in the relevant field of 'externalities' have had enough evidence to speak authoritatively against the technology in question, the industry in question has grown powerful enough as a financial entity to resist dissent or silence it altogether. Remember the response of Big Oil when climate change science began emerging (and ever since.)

3. Tech in a Future Society: a wiser relationship?

The acceleration of AI brings us to the present day in terms of society's increasingly fraught and destabilising relationship with technology. Exponential AI features ever more frequently among the list of humanity's crises. Thanks to its radical potential to reshape the conditions of human life, the threat it poses is existential. But this threshold also reveals an equally radical, generative possibility: the chance to imagine a more conscious cultural paradigm. So how might a future society relate to tech, such that it once again serves human values, instead of determining them?

A satisfying answer depends upon understanding a crucial feature of our current cultural paradigm, that maintains our inability to resist advancing tech.

3.1 Restoring agency: beyond collective action problems

If we don't race ahead, others will: **accelerating AI is a classic collective action problem - where cooperation would benefit all, but short-term competition drives everyone toward long-term harm. At its root are paradigmatic views of separateness and rivalry, which must transform if we are to meet global challenges like AI, climate, and nuclear risk wisely.**

In the public conversation around AI, including among very senior industry figures, the question repeatedly arises: given the risk, both known and unknowable, *should we pause development to consider the consequences?*

The typical answer goes to the heart of our biggest technological dilemma: "we *can't.*" Or, rather, technically, we could - but if we pause, another player will overtake us, and get all the money / power / prestige that could have been ours. *If Open AI doesn't, Google will. If Google doesn't, the next innovator funded to the hilt by blind venture capital will.* In the short term at least, no major actor is *incentivised* to slow down and consider the profound technology that they're about to unleash, and its consequences for all humanity. Government could in theory stop them - but this would take an unusual effort of collective will, especially as legislation is often beholden to profit-making in the short term, and manufacturers increasingly litigious where they encounter limitations.

We romanticise technology as our path to a better world. But surely in an ideal world, there would be a moratorium.[34] Six months, perhaps, for the world's leading philosophers, spiritual leaders, technologists, facilitators to ask: *is this what we want? Do we want it now?* And *how do we contain it?* Physically, we are free to choose this - but our collective psychology leaves us hamstrung.

[34] 33,000 signatories to The Future of Life institute's open letter on the subject include prominent industry leaders.

This is the race to the bottom; a species of collective action problem, where competing parties seek an advantage by degrading standards - resulting in a downward spiral, with dangerous systemic consequences that could ultimately harm all parties.

What's a collective action problem?

A collective action problem[35] is a situation in which all parties would benefit (typically longer term) from cooperating, but are incentivised by (typically shorter term) individual interests to withhold their own contribution.

For example:
If the whole group stays to defend the fort together, some will likely die in the ensuing battle, but most will live and the enemy will be repelled. Anyone who abandons the fort may guarantee their own safety, providing that others stay behind to win the battle. However, if a significant number attempt to save themselves, the battle will be lost, the key defensive position overcome - and all will be killed.

In our current historic moment, all of our greatest global threats rest upon collective action problems.[36] Take for example, nuclear proliferation. We live in a world where massive populations are still suffering poverty, famine and curable disease, while multiple countries regularly spend billions updating their arsenal to maintain a stalemate with others whose capability is escalating. Should we all put down our guns? Sure! (*You first, though.*)

For example, the climate crisis. We don't lack the understanding, the policy tools or even the resource to tackle climate change at a global scale. What we do lack is the necessary frame of global collectivism, or capacity for collective action. Any country

[35] Or social dilemma, or coordination failure
[36] See e.g. Schmachtenberger (2023)

undertaking to make the necessary sacrifices unilaterally risks putting itself in an unfavourable position economically, so all choose the 'freerider' path that ultimately leads to collapse.

In all of these situations, choosing the ethical path unilaterally doesn't help. Inherent power asymmetry favours those who choose to compete over those who resist competition. When it comes to AI, the 'take it slow and think about it' community is outgunned by the 'grab the power and do it now' community. In the climate space, the 'degrowth and slower living' community is overpowered by the fossil fuel-powered status quo. The same is true in the context of geopolitics. In a setting of conflict, the country that chooses to pause on the creation of potentially dangerous tech risks rapidly being outcompeted - even *defeated* - by the country that ploughs ahead in its own short term interest.

"if you had a peaceful civilization and Genghis Khan wanted that area… your peaceful civilization was wiped out. The same is true if you want to internalize all of the cost of carbon: your country is going to get destroyed geopolitically by whoever externalizes that cost and concentrates profit. The thing that has been more successfully dominant, extracted more, grown its population more increased its violence capability wins. And that thing plus exponential Tech, at planetary boundaries, self-terminates. So either we're at the end of our species, or we're at the end of our species being defined by those parameters."[37]

[37] Schmachtenberger (2023) (2)

Towards an antidote: seeking the root cause

Our current paradigm of separateness and competition fuels a race-to-the-bottom in technology and beyond. Yet history shows humanity can overcome such traps, when culture provides a sense of belonging, duty, and shared meaning. In a secular and pluralistic age, our challenge is to discover what values and narratives can play this role.

Collective action problems can appear intractable. No simple plea to common humanity will solve them - even as multiple threats from climate, escalating tech and nuclear proliferation drive humanity towards a precipice. Nonetheless it is now equally clear that any future society that survives its own technologies will be one that is no longer prone to collective action problems.

This requirement points beyond any moral reasoning possible within the modern paradigm; toward a deeper shift in how we understand ourselves and our relationship to one another: in our cultural paradigm.

Our collective action problem around runaway technology can be traced to an innate human tendency, amplified by the dominant worldview of modernity. Evolutionary biology shows that humans are both collaborative *and* competitive beings. Within families and communities, between groups, and across the cultural arenas that shape survival, working both with and against one another has at different times served our evolutionary 'success'. But the current cultural paradigm systematically amplifies a distorted Neo-Darwinian story of separate entities, competing for mastery of a given environment: accelerating a race to the bottom.[38] Modern political and economic systems - even our education systems - are structured as contests. Meanwhile consumerism, status competition, and productivity metrics all reward competitive

[38] While Darwin (e.g. 1871) himself recognised the role of cooperation in human evolution, modernity elevated only the competitive strand, folding it into its broader logic of individualism and control. *"Those communities, which included the greatest number of the most sympathetic members, would flourish best, and rear the greatest number of offspring."*

behaviours. All enact and reinforce the sense of reality as fundamentally divided and rivalrous. Competitive markets have become the dominant metaphor for human flourishing, entrenching zero-sum logic throughout society, particularly among innovators steeped in these forces. Within our institutionally competitive systems, "we" must create the dangerous technology because if "we" don't, "others" will.[39]

Shared meaning as a foundation of collective action

Humanity has a long history of orienting towards our collaborative potential and overcoming collective action problems. Many great collaborative achievements in the history of human civilizations demonstrate this capacity.[40] Yet often, it was not the logic of collectivism alone that made them possible, but an emotional or even spiritual force - a deep sense of belonging and shared duty - that underpinned common cause.

Example: religion and Subak cooperation on irrigation

"Because the Goddess makes the waters flow, those who do not follow her laws may not possess her rice terraces" [41]

The Subak irrigation system in Bali is a cooperative water management system dating back to the 9th century. The system placed obligations on individual farmers, such as limiting their own use of water, and keep their segment of the irrigation system clean to

[39] Thus metamodernists such as Daniel Görtz -among many others - locate this plight not in the plain existence of competitive mindsets, but their dominance without being tempered by deeper solidarities and higher-order forms of cooperation. A wiser approach doesn't reject competition outright (collapsing back into rivalry) but integrates and transforms it towards a life-affirming dynamics: *"who is kindest, most transparent, has greatest integrity..."* Görtz (2023)

[40] From monumental structures to scientific breakthroughs, it would be naive to suggest that all 'great achievements' emerged through cooperation alone, without domination and exploitation. Nonetheless a foundational capacity of humanity is cooperation among large groups, rooted in shared systems of meaning (see e.g. Lent (2017)).

[41] J. Stephen Lansing (1991) (p73)

avoid infestation.[42] All might benefit individually in the short term from overusing water or avoiding the work of maintenance. But all would lose if the whole system broke down. The system has been highly successful, supporting flourishing Balinese rice crops - but this is not the only motivating factor. The system is integrated within a culture - centred around not just an irrigation system but a number of water *temples* - sacred symbols and loci of common identity, ritual, belonging, as well as ethical behaviour. The whole system expresses the *TRI HITA KARANA* philosophy that unites spirit, the human world and nature. Rice is viewed as a gift from god, and water temple rituals emphasise humans' dependence on the life-giving natural world, promoting respect.

History is replete with examples of cultural and religious factors expanding and bonding circles of identity. While we wouldn't suggest that organised religion is necessary in overcoming collective action problems, it's likely that culture and shared systems of belief are critical factors.

The water-temple model did not originate as a strategic tool for promoting collectivism, however. In this case, collectivism and a particular metaphysical belief system have co-arisen. So, in a society that has already been steeped in several centuries of secularism and materialism - and that has learned difficult historic lessons from cynical efforts to manipulate populations by imposing religious belief - what views and values might support a comparable effect?

[42] Wilson (2002)

Interbeing

Today's crises arise from the illusion of separateness, which drives competition and corrodes the commons. Awareness of interconnection - in families, communities, and widening circles of care - has always guided human cooperation. Existential risks call for a worldview of 'interbeing': no life exists in isolation.

"The world is now too dangerous for anything less than utopia."

- R. Buckminster Fuller[43]

"The verb 'to be' can be misleading, because we cannot be by ourselves alone. 'To be' is always to inter-be. If we combine the prefix 'inter-' with the verb 'to be,' we have a new verb, 'inter-be.' To inter-be and the reality of interbeing is not just a word. It is a reality."

- Thich Nhat Hanh[44]

In related essays we explore the concept of **interbeing.** Coined by - hello again - Zen Master Thich Nhat Hanh, the term describes a way of understanding humanity as deeply interdependent with all life. From this point of view, the independent entity is an illusion: to exist is to be fundamentally interconnected with the rest of existence.

Talk of interbeing risks sounding hopelessly utopian, from within our dominant, individualistic cultural paradigm - and with armed conflict escalating and authoritarian values on the rise. But this anxiety still says more about a prevailing worldview than the idea itself. Indeed, interdependency isn't just a pretty story, it's a fundamental fact of life; which is precisely why in most cases - and certainly when it comes to planetary, existential risk - nobody benefits from the race to the bottom in the longer term. Prioritising the separate individual at the cost of harm to the commons eventually undermines the whole, because the story of fundamental separateness *runs counter to*

[43] Fuller (1969)
[44] Thich Nhat Hanh (1991)

reality.[45] By contrast, a worldview congruent with reality sees the inherent harmfulness of such action. When we perceive identity *with* each other and our world, there are no externalities: it makes little sense to act against the shared interests of the whole.

True, it would be naive to hope that humanity will abandon all competition and simply hold hands. Yet mistaking our collective action problems for 'realism' about human nature steers humanity off a rapidly approaching cliff. Right now, it seems, we cannot afford not to be a little utopian. We urgently require embodied, lived awareness of our interbeing - such that attitudes of collaboration and collectivism become second nature. Not to eliminate our (likewise innate and often useful) individuating and competitive drives, but to allow them a different expression, in a life-preserving context.[46]

Cultivating a sense of interbeing

Beyond the spiritual implications of interbeing, its practical expressions are highly accessible, and awareness easy to cultivate even in a secular context through simple acts of imagination. The food we eat on any given day is thanks to myriad contributing factors, from growers and producers to the land and weather. From power to shelter, theres very little that we currently depend upon, that we could create or maintain by ourselves.

Indeed, a felt sense of interbeing is not totally alien within modern life. Families demonstrate the power of sensed interbeing every day. Many of us have loved ones we would die for. Children whose snot becomes our own snot. And throughout human history we have widened that circle of care, concern and connectedness. People run into burning buildings to save other people's children. They die for their nation; for people

[45] For example, arguably our greatest collective action problem - climate breakdown - stems from insufficient awareness of humanity's interconnection with our ecosphere.

[46] A worldview of interbeing should not be mistaken for denial of the individual - rather recognising separateness as a partial view and restoring balance by including its opposite. An expanded view of human life can hold the polarity of individual and interconnected, helping to rebalance where one side has grown dominant, to the detriment of the whole.

they have never met. For people they met a week ago, or those who have not yet been born. Christianity is founded on this principle.

As we're taught by Buddhism (and indeed by many world religions and spiritual teachers), self transcendence isn't just a lovely way to relax. It's a truth about the world, the realisation of which is profoundly liberating, because our illusion of separateness is the source of all our suffering. Physically and mentally, we are part of everything and each other. As such, acting in accordance with interbeing, and not against it, usually produces a result worth having. From the most banal case to the most profound. *I wash someone else's cup and plate along with my own, and before long I notice that someone else has washed mine. The protected fort repels the attack and most of the people survive. Everyone destroys all their nuclear weapons at once and we don't wipe each other out (only kidding).*

Cultivation of the inner capacities that support a sense of interbeing, at a scale of large societies, may seem like a profound challenge. But we're capable of it, and on some scales we're moving in the right direction. Despite the rise of individualism, throughout human history the net direction of travel has been towards widening circles of concern. We already agree to pay taxes to support the wellbeing of others - and we understand that, should we need it, that same system (theoretically) supports us. Expanding our sphere of concern can in turn help develop the understanding that interbeing isn't metaphorical - that we're deeply interwoven with others.

3.2 Escaping the tyranny of tech: how could a future society make better choices? (Or, how do we learn to want what's good?)

True freedom requires not just the option to choose but the capacity to choose wisely. A future society must cultivate deeper awareness, discernment, and inner capacities to guide technology in service of human flourishing.

A future free from wicked collective action problems likely requires a profound inner shift at the level of dominant culture: towards a shared worldview of interbeing. Shifts in collective worldview don't just happen because we want them to. But throughout history, new paradigm thinking has often emerged in 'pockets': small, dense groups of innovators engaging in 'conscious culture-making' and experimenting with new (or renewed) ways of being, thinking and acting together. These 'islands of coherence' are surrounded by mainstream cultures still operating the earlier dominant paradigm, and often act as a source of cultural leadership.[47]

At the cutting edge of tech leadership today, incubators like Y-Combinator in San Francisco are responsible for helping accelerate tech startups. These are the gatekeepers of the technology that gets to be born in the late modern age. As disciples of modern market ideology, the motivations for their choices are often distorted.[48] Nonetheless, considering our earlier assertion that the current age looks to technologists for leadership, we might wishfully imagine a 'Y-combinator for the Second Renaissance' acting as a 'pocket' of new paradigm thinking. If values relating to interbeing were to supplant allegiance to progress and profit, how might such a group

[47] Barbier et al (2024) outlines this concept in greater detail

[48] As discussed in section 2.2, Modern rationalism models human individuals as autonomous, utility-maximising agents, assuming that when everyone acts in their own self-interest, the collective good will somehow emerge. In the context of choosing technology, this fiction allows profit-seeking to masquerade as public benefit, and enables corporations to manipulate non-rational behaviour in ways that often undermine wellbeing - especially when new applications are designed to exploit attention, emotion, and impulse.

discern those values? Beyond the limited scope of reason and logic, what capacities might enable them to choose tech that truly serves humanity? In short, how might a future society achieve the creation of technology in wise ways, for wise purposes?

Restoring 'consumer' agency: everyday spaciousness

As the Zen master's account of 'false needs' reminds us, where modern market dogma claims that reason guides consumer choices, plainly other unspoken motivational qualities are always in play. Impulse; emotion; aversion….these signals can misfire; particularly in an economy designed to amplify our cravings and fears and accelerate our consumption.[49] Nonetheless they aren't themselves inherently misleading - often they carry real information that our rationalist culture has trained us to overlook or mistrust. With time, space and awareness we are capable of refining and attuning to the embodied signals that *assist* our reasoning in choosing what's good for us. Even pausing to think before reacting can be enough for common sense to reassert itself. A future society with a healthier relationship to tech would surely prioritise slowness, sensing and discernment over instant gratification. However, supporting such spacious conditions requires in turn a tech economy that does not incentivise attention-hacking, corrosive consumer technology - healthier choicemaking at a deeper; societal level.

Far-reaching choices: deeper wisdom

To make far-reaching choices on behalf of self *or* society requires more than everyday spaciousness and common sense. It calls for broad, continuous, committed, value-aligned awareness, typically offline in the course of modern life. We might call this deeper stratum *wisdom* - combining the reasoning born of life experience, historical understanding and complex thinking with a raft of hard-won *trans-rational* qualities

[49] Consider all the features of consumer tech built to amplify impatience and accelerate buying; from next-day delivery to in-app purchasing.

such as intuition, insight, sensitivity, valueception, and collective care. Nothing new or beyond our grasp - yet modern, tech driven have sidelined cultivation of these powerful inner qualities, in governance, as elsewhere. At this critical time for human survival, we can no longer afford to treat them as if they aren't real, or important to our collective survival and flourishing.[50]

A wise future society wouldn't abandon reason or science in choosing technology, but rather restore trust and cultivation of wisdom as a pillar of sense-making, in this most consequential arena. Humans possess the capacity for deep, ongoing curiosity about what's unfolding, how we feel about it, and what we really want in the longer term. Individually and collectively, vast scope exists for cultivating an inner compass; the subtle senses that help to tell us whether we're headed towards what's good in our lives and our societies. An unhurried, reflective, iterative process of discerning what we want to bring into the world - and learning how to bring it about in a skilful way. These natural faculties are eminently within our grasp. Our current speed-fixated, technological ideology doesn't make space for this kind of wisdom.

Conclusion

The godlike status of technology has become a vicious circle throughout the modern age. The more machines empowers us, the more willingly we defer to them; reducing ourselves, our values and our world to a mechanistic, material logic and thereby rendering ourselves less and less capable of resisting technological momentum. So confident have we felt in our own rational agency that we have gradually outsourced responsibility for our decision-making to an unconscious entity. So firmly have we believed that more technology is the best thing for us, that we have dismissed warnings of excess and destroyed much of real value in our world. As such, restoring wise

[50] A forthcoming essay series explores this concept of wisdom in greater depth.

relationship with technology first requires transforming our impoverished, computational view of what it means to be human.

If humanity is to avoid self-annihilation, we must urgently reassess our capacity to choose the technologies we adopt - on the basis of a more fully dimensional understanding of ourselves: unpredictable, emotional, and rarely strictly rational in the reductive sense. But this assessment need not lead us to despair. In fact, it directs us toward the very root of wiser choice: by restoring value to the subtle, intuitive and unmeasurable dimensions of human knowing - long sidelined by reductive rationalism - we begin to resuscitate neglected capacities essential to wise decision-making.

The revolution that we require does not begin and end with inner capacities. At their root, the tech-entangled rivalries that threaten us with annihilation point to a fundamental misunderstanding of reality - and of our relationship to one another and the living world. Among renewed ethical, spiritual, and philosophical views that can re-humanise our sense of what matters and restore neglected dimensions of value, a worldview alive to interbeing appears indispensable if we are to survive collective action problems. For people living isolated lives in a hyper-individualised, fragmented modern society, this may well sound like a distant ideal. However, understanding of radical interdependency will be foundational to any future culture that can escape today's existential dilemmas - and restore technology as a servant to that which is most human, most relational, and most conducive to life.

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